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UAE UNVEILS TRAVEL PUSH, BILLIONS IN INVESTMENT

NEW TRAVEL
PACKAGES,
AIRCRAFT AND
ATTRACTIONS
EMERGE AS GULF
TOURISM PLOTS
ITS NEXT MOVE

DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

The Gulf's tourism industry is looking beyond nearly seven months of the US-Iran conflict and ensuing disruption, with policymakers and industry leaders at Arabian Travel Market in Dubai pointing to preparedness, collaboration and fresh investment as the keys to its next phase of growth.

The opening day of ATM 2026 brought together tourism and aviation leaders from across the region and beyond, with new travel products, aircraft, airlines and attractions unveiled as the industry returned to one of its biggest annual gatherings. UAE Minister of Economy and Tourism Abdulla Bin Touq Al Marri said the UAE's ability to navigate recent shocks was built on decades of investment in the country's



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■ His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, takes a tour of the Arabian Travel Market yesterday.

tourism foundations. "Everyone talks about tourism resiliency; I talk about tourism foundations," Al Marri said. "What has been built over the last 50 years is the foundation of what we have seen in recent months."

UN Tourism Secretary-Gener-

al Shaikha Al Nuwais said preparation and relationships built before a crisis were critical to the region's ability to respond. "The countries that handle crises best are the ones that prepare before they happen," she said. "They build relationships early, they

share information and they build trust."

Dubai, meanwhile, welcomed about seven million tourists in the first eight months of 2026, while visitors booked around 21 million hotel room nights during the period.

11-DAY UAE TOUR

The UAE has launched uaegrandtour.com, a new booking platform offering 11-day, 10-night holidays across all seven emirates. Packages start from Dh10,446 per person and include selected four and five-star hotels, private transport, guided sightseeing, entrance fees, meals and experiences such as a Dubai Creek abra ride and desert safari.

Al Marri said the initiative is designed to encourage visitors to stay longer and explore more. It offers themed options including Grand Classic, Grand Adventure, Grand Beaches, Grand Eco Friendly and Grand Family. The Grand Classic covers Dubai, Sharjah, Ajman, Fujairah, Ras Al Khaimah, Abu Dhabi and Al Ain.

— Nivetha Dayanand,
Assistant Business Editor

seats, with the first A330 due to enter service from September 2027. Etihad plans to add 15 A330s over five years and has outlined a \$20 billion investment in new aircraft and customer experience, including a \$1 billion fleet retrofit programme.

Yas expansion

At Yas Island, Miral plans to invest more than Dh12 billion over the next five years, adding new attractions and immersive experiences, upgrading existing theme parks and expanding hotel capacity. The investment is separate from the previously announced Disney project.

Taken together, the first day of ATM offered a snapshot of an industry moving from crisis management towards expansion — with governments focused on resilience and connectivity, while tourism companies invest in the aircraft, attractions and experiences.

New airline

Saudi Arabia also moved closer to adding another major low-cost airline. An Air Arabia-led consortium received its Air Operator Certificate from GACA to launch a new national budget carrier based at Dammam's King Fahd International Airport.

SEE ALSO P-II, III

Dubai to get 4 Etihad Rail stations

Two to serve high-speed rail line between Abu Dhabi and Dubai

DUBAI
BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

Dubai will have four stations linked to the Etihad Rail network, two of which will serve the upcoming high-speed rail line between Abu Dhabi and Dubai, the city's roads authority has announced.

Mattar Al Tayer, Director General and Chairman of the Board of Executive Directors of the Roads and Transport Authority (RTA), shared the update during a press conference held to announce the inaugural RailX Dubai Conference

and Exhibition yesterday. Al Tayer said the national Etihad Rail project includes connection points within Dubai, likely through two stations, tying the emirate into the wider UAE rail network.

This means there will be one more station other than Dubai Al Yalaysi Station, Etihad Rail's main passenger station in the emirate, set to open on September 30.

Separate initiative

A second, separate initiative Etihad Rail is developing is the high-speed rail link between Dubai and Abu Dhabi. This project will also bring two stations to Dubai: one at Al Maktoum International Airport and another in Al Jaddaf, Al Tayer revealed.

These national projects will be woven into Dubai's own rail network, connecting with the Red, Green and Blue Metro lines, as well as future lines under discussion, including the proposed Gold Line, Al Tayer said.

Most of these lines are expected to interconnect through the new stations, creating links across different parts of the city.

Al Tayer said the integration is clearly laid out in the master plan, with the goal of a fully-connected transport system linking cities across the UAE with Dubai. Etihad Rail, he added, plays a central role in that vision, with the RTA working closely with the company as part of a wider, complementary transport strategy.

SEE ALSO P5

UAE passport remains world's most powerful

182 destinations visa-free, visa-on-arrival

DUBAI
BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

The UAE passport has retained its position as the world's most powerful passport in 2026, giving its holders facilitated access to 182 destinations worldwide, according to the latest September report by Passport Reports.

The UAE recorded a Mobility Score of 182, equivalent to 91.9 per cent worldwide access.

The score covers destinations that UAE passport holders can enter visa-free, obtain a visa on arrival or through other simplified

arrangements, or access using an Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA).

The ranking places the UAE ahead of other passports in terms of the breadth of international travel access available to its citizens.

Of the 182 destinations covered by the UAE's Mobility Score, 128 offer visa-free entry, while 44 are accessible through visa on arrival or other simplified entry arrangements.

A further 10 destinations require an ETA.

Only 16 destinations are classified as requiring a visa for UAE passport holders, including the United States, and Australia.



IN FOCUS

Incubator shortages, premature births at Gaza hospitals | P8-9

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